STAY SMART IN THE DIGITAL WORLD

Digital Safety Fundamentals | A practical, source-based learning guide

The big idea: The safest response to an unexpected online request is to pause, verify through an independent trusted channel, and share only what is necessary.

What you will learn

- How messages use urgency and impersonation to pressure people
- How to protect accounts with strong unique passwords and multifactor authentication
- How to verify unexpected messages and respond safely
- How to protect personal information and think critically about AI-generated media

A note about this resource

This is a fictional, general-purpose educational guide. It is not a report of real incidents, a guarantee of security, or a substitute for organisation-specific security policy. Scenarios used in companion materials are entirely invented.

Reading map

F1 Identify suspicious requests | F2 Protect accounts | F3 Keep devices and data safe | F4 Verify before acting | F5 Respond and report | F6 AI and digital trust

F1. Recognise suspicious requests

Phishing is a deception technique in which a message attempts to persuade someone to reveal sensitive information, visit a deceptive site, or open a harmful attachment. Messages can arrive through email, SMS, social platforms or workplace communication systems.

Five common warning signals

- Unexpected urgency: "Act in 10 minutes or your account will be closed."
- Impersonation: A sender claims to represent a bank, employer, college or delivery company.
- Sensitive information requests: A message asks for login codes, passwords or payment-card details.
- Strange destination: A link points to an unfamiliar domain or a mismatched address.
- Pressure to bypass normal process: The sender discourages independent checking or requests an unusual payment method.

Important: A spelling mistake is not required for a message to be fraudulent; sophisticated scams can look polished. Likewise, urgency alone does not prove fraud. Verify the request independently.

Example: An unexpected "parcel fee" text

A text says: "Your parcel cannot be delivered. Confirm your address and pay a small redelivery charge immediately." The safe next step is to open the courier service from a known app or manually typed official site - not through the message link.

F2. Protect your accounts

Digital accounts often protect personal messages, documents, contact information and payment access. Good account security is layered rather than dependent on one password.

Four practical habits

- Use a long, unique password or passphrase for each account. Avoid reusing one password across multiple sites.
- Consider a reputable password manager. It can create and store distinct passwords.
- Turn on multifactor authentication (MFA). A second factor makes account compromise harder even when a password is exposed.
- Prefer phishing-resistant sign-in methods when offered. Passkeys or security keys can provide stronger resistance than codes that can be tricked out of users.

What is MFA?

MFA means using two or more distinct pieces of evidence to sign in, such as a password plus a registered authenticator, security key or device biometric. No one should ask you to read out a one-time verification code in an unsolicited call or chat.

F3. Keep devices and information safe

- Enable operating-system, browser and application updates; security fixes help close known weaknesses.
- Back up important information using a reliable and recoverable method.
- Avoid uploading confidential work files, private identity documents or other people's data to tools without authorisation.
- Review link-sharing permissions: "Anyone with the link" can expose more information than intended.

F4. Pause. Verify. Decide.

Use a short decision routine whenever you receive an unexpected request involving accounts, money, personal data or urgent action.

1. PAUSE

Do not act from fear, excitement or pressure.

2. CHECK THE CLAIM

What is being requested? Is the message expected?

3. VERIFY INDEPENDENTLY

Open a trusted app or known official site; contact the organisation using independently found contact details.

4. PROTECT INFORMATION

Do not disclose passwords, verification codes or unnecessary personal information.

5. ACT OR REPORT

Proceed only after confirmation; otherwise report and delete or block.

> Try it: A message claims to be from your learning platform and says your account will close unless you submit a sign-in code. What would you do before opening the link?

Why independent verification matters

Scammers can disguise sender names, copy official logos, and make messages look convincing. An independently opened channel reduces your reliance on the message itself.

F5. Respond and report

If you receive a suspicious message, avoid clicking links or opening attachments. Use your messaging service's reporting features, or a reporting channel specified by your institution or organisation.

If you already responded

- Change affected credentials using the official website or application; use a trusted device if available.
- Review sign-in activity and security settings; enable or refresh MFA where appropriate.
- If financial information or funds may be affected, contact the financial institution through verified channels promptly.
- If you downloaded a suspicious file, seek appropriate IT/security assistance and scan the device.
- Preserve relevant evidence when reporting to the appropriate team or authority, without forwarding malicious links to others.

F6. AI and digital trust

AI can help draft messages, answer questions, summarise documents and create convincing text, images and audio. Those capabilities are useful, but they also make it easier for misleading or deceptive content to look credible.

Three useful checks

- Evidence: Which original source supports the claim?
- Authenticity: Could the speaker, sender, image or recording be impersonated?
- Privacy: Are you about to provide information that is unnecessary or confidential?

A realistic limitation

Not every suspicious-looking message is a scam, and not every polished, confidently written message is trustworthy. Verification and appropriate organisational procedures remain essential.

Knowledge check

Use the following questions for self-study, revision or source-grounded discussion.

Q1. Why is a short-notice message asking for a one-time login code a warning sign?

Q2. What is one safe way to verify an unexpected courier payment request?

Q3. How does MFA improve account security?

Q4. Why can an "anyone with the link" document permission be risky?

Q5. Why should an AI-generated voice message not automatically be treated as proof of identity?

Reference sources

This original learning guide synthesises general safety practices from public guidance. Consult the linked originals for authoritative and updated advice.

R1 - CISA Secure Our World: https://www.cisa.gov/secure-our-world

R2 - FTC, How To Recognize and Avoid Phishing Scams: https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/how-recognize-avoid-phishing-scams

R3 - FTC, How To Avoid a Scam: https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/how-avoid-scam

R4 - CISA four safety actions: https://www.cisa.gov/resources-tools/resources/secure-our-world-cybersecurity-awareness-month-resources

Version: October 2026 | Illustrative examples are fictional | Educational reuse permitted for the accompanying workshop material